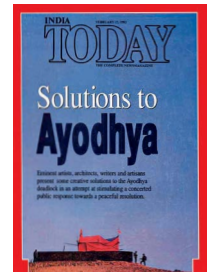
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi performed the rituals to consecrate the idol of Balak Ram, in the magnificent new Mandir at Ayodhya on January 22, India turned a chapter in its tumultuous history. It is particularly significant in a country whose history is hardly deficient in epochal and momentous events. But there are many reasons why the pran pratishtha at the new Ram temple looms way above the ordinary scale with which we measure events. Something that was a cause of political conflagrations for over three decades and a contentious dispute between Hindus and Muslims for over a century has now metamorphosed into a spectacular monument. However, it does not fully describe the profound level at which the event seeks to alter the reality of modern India.

To be sure, from the earliest days of Independent India, there have been occasions when the State had a tryst with religion. Somnath temple, for instance, was famously rebuilt on the initiative of India's first deputy prime minister, Sardar Patel. The then President of India, Rajendra Prasad, attended the installation ceremony of the Shiv Linga at the new temple ignoring Jawaharlal Nehru's reservations. But as prime minister, Modi went many steps further and performed the ritual role of yajman—or patron—of the pran pratishtha at Ayodhya. With the phenomenal force-multiplying effect of media platforms live-streaming the ceremony across the globe, the event gained unprecedented amplitude. It inundated the public sphere and seeped into millions of homes, where the devout in turn enacted rituals of worship. Some will continue to question the propriety of the prime minister, a constitutional functionary, becoming the protagonist in a religious event. What we saw, however, was large sections of the citizenry across the country granting their enthusiastic consent to that union by participating in it themselves. That is a bridge not just between politics and religion but to mass culture.



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Thus, the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) led by Modi has managed a unique feat that resonates with its very raison d'etre. It has brought to fulfilment the one 'unfinished agenda' that has been the party's defining theme since 1989, when it formally decided to take up the Ram Mandir as a cause. By doing so, it has successfully put the realm of culture and faith at the heart of the State. The very point that creates discomfiture among its critics is a gilded plate for the BJP. That India cannot proceed without anchoring itself in a cultural ethos had long been the contention of the BJP's political mentor, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS). The Sangh had defined its quest for establishing Hindutva as one of reviving India's Hindu identity, on the basis of the continuity and inclusivity of its spirituality-based traditions and Bharat's entire wealth of value systems. It saw the building of a Ram Mandir at Ayodhya, abrogating Article 370 that had given Jammu and Kashmir a unique autonomous status and the establishment of a Uniform Civil Code (UCC) as the three foundation stones for Hindutva to finally prevail.

Modi will now go down in history as the prime minister who ensured not only the fulfilment of two of the Sangh Parivar's major goals—the Ram Mandir and abrogation of Article 370—but has also furthered the cause of establishing a UCC by passing the law to ban triple talaq as ground for divorce among Muslims. And he ensured these decisions came through the legal route and had the imprimatur of the Supreme Court. But rather than a triumphal reassertion of Hindu identity, Modi was statesman-like in his speech at the Mandir after the consecration, saying, "This is not only a moment of celebrations but also a moment of realisation of the maturity of Indian society. Not one of just *vijay* (victory) but also *vinay* (humility)." He went on to link the occasion to governance ideals like Viksit Bharat, saying, "This grand Ram temple will become witness to the rise of a grand India, a developed India. This is India's time and India is going to move forward."

RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat's presence both at the consecration and on stage at the post-ceremony thanksgiving speeches, along with saffron-robed seers, took things beyond mere government participation. It lent ideological-cultural weight to the occasion. Bhagwat also took it upon himself to elaborate on the concept of Ram Rajya: he made of it a remarkably pro-people, democratic credo that had space for every opinion, for dialogue and for mutual respect and good governance. The idea of the Hindu Rashtra he puts forth, therefore, is not exclusively 'Hindu'. Rather, it's a benevolent and rooted culture of conversations, which he offered as the very soul of India. Whether such an ideal is realised in practice is what India will be looking forward to. But what all these developments symbolise is a great Hindu revival that will have a major bearing on how India proceeds as a nation.

Implicitly, with the general election not too far away, it is fair to assume that Modi and the BJP's campaign for a third consecutive term with a full majority in the Lok Sabha will get a major boost. The consecration ceremony had put the Opposition led by the Congress into strategic confusion: if they refused to accept the invitation to be present, they risked being dubbed anti-Hindu; if they attended the ceremony, they would be seen as crediting the BJP and the RSS for bringing to closure a historically fractious and emotive religious issue. The Congress chose to boycott the consecration, accusing Modi of converting it into a political event. Rahul Gandhi stayed on course with his Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra, preferring to try and visit Batadrava Than, one of Assam's most important holy places, on that day—though he was blocked. Odisha chief minister Naveen Patnaik did a parallel masterstroke to that of Modi's by inaugurating the redevelopment of the Jagannath Temple at Puri days before the Ram Mandir ceremony. Not to be outdone, the BJP government in UP led by Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath has begun spectacularly transforming Ayodhya into a pilgrimage hub that's being called 'the new Vatican' of Hinduism. It is also noteworthy that, barring some stray communal incidents, the event went off largely peacefully.

In this special issue, we bring you exhaustive coverage of both the event and its many-sided resonances and consequences, including answering the big question: Will the grand Hindu revival change India and lead to Ram Rajya? Consider it our humble offering to reach for exactly what our epics would want of us.

(Aroon Purie)